

[Home](#)⇒ [College Guide](#)⇒ **01. Timeline of the Application Process**

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- [Taking the National Exams \(KCSE\)](#)
 - [Taking Standardized Tests \(SAT, ACT, English-Proficiency\)](#)
 - [School Search](#)
 - [Completing the College Applications](#)
 - [Applying for Financial Aid](#)
 - [Admission Notification](#)
 - [Get Your Kenyan Passport Ready](#)
 - [Get Your Student Visa Stamp](#)
 - [Travel Prep and Departure](#)
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The following are steps and the general timelines in the application process. We'll address these steps in more detail later on.

In Kenya, a college is different from a university. In the US, "college" corresponds to "university" in Kenyan terms. This website uses "college" and "university" to mean the same thing.

Taking the National Exams (KCSE)

The application process usually begins after completing high school, which is marked by taking the KCSE.

The main challenges to submitting US college applications while still in high school are lack of time (schedules tend to be packed with KCSE prep) and lack of access to the internet (you'll need to research your options).

International schools have a calendar that is more accommodating to US college applications. The authors of this website went through the 8-4-4 system, so our advice on the college application timeline is based on what we had.

Although the KCSE is not a requirement to your US college application, ensure that you do well on it. Many Kenyan students apply to US colleges and get rejected. Others gain admission, but they cannot afford to pay. It's crucial that you do well on the KCSE to secure yourself a seat in one of the Kenyan universities.

Taking Standardized Tests (SAT, ACT, English-Proficiency)

You may think of standardized tests as the equivalent of the KCSE in the US. The major difference is that the tests are offered multiple times during the year, and you may retake them.

The test content does not completely overlap with what we learn in the Kenyan system. You'll need time to get used to the test and [do lots of practice](#).

You should take your standardized tests early enough to meet application deadlines. Most applications deadlines are in late December, so you'll need to take the required tests by November.

See [07. Tests That You Need to Take](#) and [08. Test Preparation Resources](#) for more info.

School Search

Many applicants find themselves having “dream schools”, which is not a bad thing, but you need to widen your net to a few safety schools. As much as you may really want to go to a certain school simply because you have heard about it, it's not always guaranteed that it is your best match. It is important to embark on an intensive school search process.

See [09. Examples of US universities that Kenyans have attended on scholarships](#) and [10. When Considering a University, What Should You Look For?](#).

There is more to the US than Harvard. Don't be fooled by the term “safety schools”. Safety schools that still offer financial aid to international students accept around 10% of applicants, so they're still competitive.

Furthermore, schools may have different testing requirements. The earlier you decide on the set of schools that you'll be applying to, the more focused your preparation will be.

Completing the College Applications

See [12. High School Transcript, School Report and Letters of Recommendation](#) for items that you'll need from your high school.

Don't underestimate the time needed for this. Your teachers will be busy preparing the seniors for the KCSE. Start early.

Most schools accept the Common Application. This is the platform where you fill in your application details, respond to school-specific essay prompts, and submit your applications. See [14. Common Application Essays and Writing Supplements](#) for more information.

Used to be that accounts get wiped every year, but that's no longer so. Feel free to create an account, and get a feel of the application requirements. The essay prompts may change from year to year, but everything else is mostly constant. [Thanks Ahmed for pointing this out!]

There are two deadlines for college applications. The first one is in October/ November for your top choice, while the other one is in December/January for additional schools. See [13. Early Action \(EA\)/ Single Choice Early Action \(SCEA\)/ Early Decision \(ED\) & Regular Decision \(RD\)](#).

Some schools schedule an interview between you and an alumni after receiving your application.

Applying for Financial Aid

Applying for financial aid (e.g. a scholarship) is separate from your college application. For early applications, the deadline is in November, while for regular applications, the deadline is in January/February. Schools may have their separate application process for financial aid. See [15. Financial Aid Applications](#)

Scholarships are typically called "grants" because you don't pay for them. Another form of financial aid are student loans. These need to be paid back. Similar to [Kenya's HELB Loans](#).

Admission Notification

The moment you've been waiting for! If you applied early, you'll get the school's decision in December. Otherwise, you'll get in March/April. Godspeed! See [16. Receiving Admissions Decisions](#)

Get Your Kenyan Passport Ready

Passport processing time may vary. If you don't have a passport, get one ASAP. Don't wait till you hear back from the universities. Spare yourself the trouble of anxiously camping outside the passport application office for days on end.

At the very least, you want to get one by April so that when you can start the visa application process as soon as possible.

Get Your Student Visa Stamp

After committing to attend a university, they'll send you a form that you'll present to the US Embassy in Kenya to get a student visa. Visa interview slots may run out so book yours early. See [17. The I-20 Form, SEVIS Fee and Visa Interview](#)

Additionally, getting your visa early allows you to book the flight early enough to get cheaper tickets. See [18. Coming to the US - Travel Arrangements > Booking Flights](#).

Travel Prep and Departure

There are a couple things to take care of: vaccinations, booking a flight, shopping, etc. See [18. Coming to the US - Travel Arrangements](#)

September is now here. It's time to leave for your new home. Your school may send someone to pick you up from the airport. Another option is to use Uber/Lyft. While there is public transit, you don't want to miss a stop or get confused if you need to make several switches.

[02. What will you gain from US universities? »](#)

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